

GENDER

Bengal Remembers: Sengar, Epstein, and RG Kar's Legacy on International Women's Day in 2026

A photo essay from International Women's Day, 8th March 2026, at Jantar Mantar, where women from six to sixty gathered to protest the BJP government's neglect of women's safety and welfare, express solidarity with the women of Palestine and Iran, and raise demands for dignity, health, and work.

BY MOULI SHARMA

Photographs from Jantar Mantar on the 8th of March 2026

Various women's organisations in Delhi celebrated the International Women's Day on 8th March 2026 by gathering at Jantar Mantar and protesting against the BJP government's neglect of women's welfare, safety, and progress. Women from all ages, between 6 and 60, were present. They sang for revolution, they sloganeered against fascism, and they spat at the grave of Brahminical Patriarchy that they have spent 3000 excruciating years digging.

The women declared their solidarity with the women of the world, particularly with the women of Palestine and Iran who are under imperialist attacks by America and Zionist Israel and also announced their opposition to the policies of liberalization, privatization and globalization which they deemed to be sources of women's suffering. The demonstrators also expressed dissatisfaction against the state which they claimed protects patriarchy and the interests of the corporates at the cost of women, and they raised important demands for basic rights to dignity, health, safety, security, work, education among others.

Above all, women from all backgrounds broke all barriers to come together to raise and amplify their voices.

The protesters also raised demands for the regulation of female dominated labour sectors such as domestic work and provision of minimum wage for the same, abolition of female feticide and female infanticide. They also condemned the impunity enjoyed by perpetrators of sexual violence all over the world, such as Kuldeep Singh Sengar and the high-profile politicians, celebrities, academics, corporatists, among others named in the Epstein files.

Women's organisations like the All India Progressive Women's Association (AIPWA), Pragatisheel Mahila Sangathan (Progressive Women's Association or PMS), and Sangharshsheel Mahila Kendra (Centre for Struggling Women or CSW), Purogami Mahila Sangathan (Pioneering Women's Organisation), All India Mahila Samskritik Sanghatan (All India Women's Cultural Organisation or AIMSS), All India Democratic Women's Association (AIDWA); NGO's like Action India and Aasha Foundation; as well as theatre groups like the Jan Natya Manch were present at the event.

Towards the end of the event, after the police directed the women's organisations to clear the area, individuals from the Abhaya Manch in Bengal protested till (and a little past) being instructed to leave the site on grounds of their 'unpermitted and hence illegal' demonstration - that on the brutal RG Kar rape and murder of Moumita Debnath on 9 th August 2024.

As mentioned above, the impunity to rapists all over the country such as Kuldeep Singh Sengar, Ram Rahim, Asaram Bapu, Brij Bhushan Singh Yadav, Prajwal Revanna (and countless others), politicians named in the Epstein files, etc. was a primary concern (alongside the demand for regulation of female dominated labour sectors such as domestic work and provision of minimum wage for the same, female feticide and infanticide rates, etc) of the initial protest as well, but this felt different. To the silent observer's eye, for a moment, it felt as though Bengal remembers.

Kolkata remembers.



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